Eudaimonia

A Philosophy/Psychology Publication



Spring 2025

Issue 1

Finding Purpose at Hotchkiss

Sharing the Stories and Wisdom of the Hotchkiss Community

Eudaimonia

[yü-dī-’mō-nē-ə] - noun - Greek

A state of happiness, well-being, and flourishing that comes from living a life of purpose, virtue, and excellence

Author’s Note

Eudaimonia is a philosophy and psychology-based publication that aims to share the unique insight of our diverse Hotchkiss community. This institution is a convergence of unique individuals with vastly different backgrounds. This publication seeks to uncover the stories that shape us — moments of quiet resilience, bold ambitions, and the often overlooked in-between moments of transition. Some of us are athletes chasing dreams, others are people battling mental adversity or learning to thrive in new cultural landscapes. Here, mistakes can feel momentous or successes can feel fleeting, but beneath it all, is a shared humanity —a desire to grow, belong, and matter. By sharing pieces of ourselves, we seek to relate and learn about one another, understand different perspectives and mindsets, and ultimately guide each other towards eudaimonia.

This publication issue is themed “Finding Purpose at Hotchkiss” and contains the personal philosophy/psychology, stories, challenges, and wisdom from many different people of the community, including students, student-athletes, and your very own teachers. Our writers have decided to share personal pieces of themselves in hopes of helping you find purpose at Hotchkiss. We hope that you take the time to read through, learn about your peers, feel the pulse of this community, and maybe learn something about yourself.

Philip Lee ‘26 and Andrew Lee ’26

Eudaimonia
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Finding Purpose as an Athlete

The moment I kicked a soccer ball for the first time, my name became synonymous with the sport. Whether it was at school, at the dinner table, or even during vacations, a soccer ball was always attached to my feet. Soccer fused into my identity, stitching itself into the very fabric that made me Chrys Yue. I always dreamed of being a professional soccer player, doing what I loved in exchange for money, fame, and most importantly, happiness.

Luckily for me, I was pretty good at soccer, too. I captained academy teams of professional soccer clubs in Hong Kong and came close to representing my nation on multiple occasions.

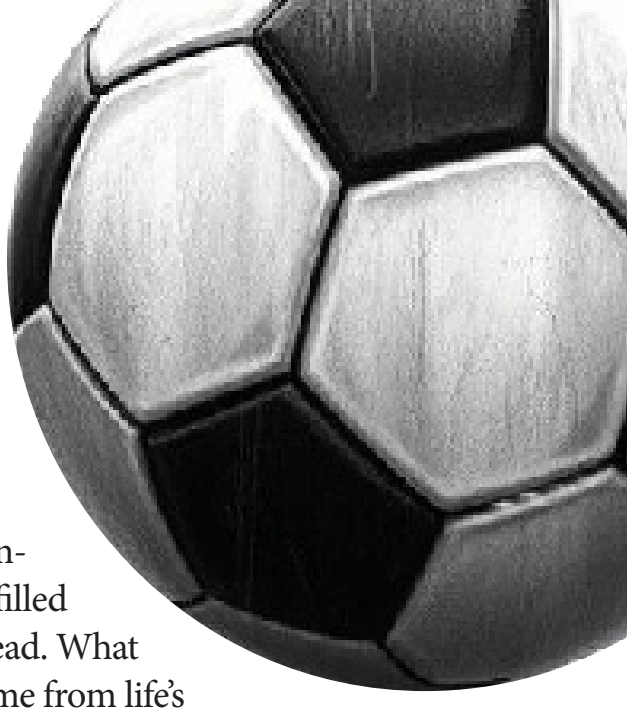
But when I turned 15, I was hit with a reality check: I had to choose between school and soccer. Back home in Hong Kong, almost every parent wouldn’t allow their son to focus solely on being a professional athlete. Even though my parents knew how much I loved soccer, they insisted on prioritizing academics. Doing well in school, going to a good college, and getting a job that paid well was the only path to a “successful and worthwhile” life. They tried to ingrain in me that soccer was merely a hobby, a pastime that would bring me up when the important things in life brought me down.

I rejected this notion. I loved soccer too much. I started searching for a new path – one that satisfied my parents’ vision of education and my need to keep playing.

America offered that balance. I applied to prep schools and chose Hotchkiss for one reason: Coach Williams. Our relationship was built on trust. I was committed to bettering both the soccer program and myself as a student-athlete.

And, in a way, I was right. My first season at Hotchkiss was a personal success. I came in as a new lower-mid and became a regular starter on the varsity team, taking on defenders on the wing and delivering assists. I missed six games due to injury, but every minute I played felt like home.

Even during the off-season, I trained hard. I joined United Soccer Group, a club made up of serious players from Salisbury, Berkshire, and Millbrook. I trained daily and loved the grind.



My hard work paid off. I was named a captain of the varsity team in just my second year. I couldn't wait for junior fall to score goals, dribble past defenders, and win games. That summer, I trained in Hong Kong's blistering 100°F heat with my former academy team, working on my first touch, shooting, and fitness. I had the trust of my coaches, teammates, and myself.

Our season kicked off with a preseason trip to England – watching Premier League matches, training with elite coaches, and playing against academy teams that produce top talent. Against Queens Park Rangers' Academy, I put on a performance to remember, even earning recognition from their coaching staff. Even back in America, I spent the first few games on a hot streak, attacking the opposition with one objective in mind: putting the ball in the back of the net.

But in game five, we lost our starting center back and right back to injury. Coach Williams moved me to defense for that game and then for most of the season.

I'm not a defender, and I never was. As a kid, I dreamed of scoring goals, not stopping them. For the first time, I had to adapt to a completely different role. And I sucked at it. Fear coursed through me every time an opponent ran at me. I was locked in a single mindset: Don't get humiliated. My confidence shattered with every goal we conceded.

For the first time, I didn't enjoy playing soccer. Practices became painful. Games filled me with dread. What once freed me from life's stressors became the very source of them. I began to hate the game. I'd cry at night, unsure why the thing that once defined me now felt so empty.

At the end, I managed to finish the season with the team. Though our record was one of the worst in recent years, I stuck with the team and played until the very end. It sucked and, for a few months after the season ended, I thought I'd never want to touch a soccer ball again.

From loving the game to dreading it, I learned two things:

One: Don't let one thing drive your happiness.

For most of my life, soccer was my happiness. Every emotion I felt was tied to the field – when I played well, I felt unstoppable; when I didn't, I felt I had nothing left to offer. I let my self-worth hinge entirely on how I performed with a ball at my feet, and

the higher I rose, the more terrified I became of falling.

So when things went wrong, when I lost confidence, when I started dreading practices, when soccer stopped feeling like mine, it wasn't just the game that slipped away, I did too. I had no backup plan for happiness. I hadn't nurtured other parts of who I was. My relationships, my curiosity, my joy in simply living meant nothing without soccer anchoring me. I felt lost.

This is where I learned how dangerous it is to pour everything into one thing, no matter how much you love it. True happiness needs more than one source. It needs balance, perspective, and space to breathe.



Two, always prioritize joy over performance.

At first, I loved playing soccer because the game itself was fun to me. Scoring goals, playing the perfect pass to set your teammate up, dribbling past your opponents through your instincts, I found joy in that. But when I started to believe that being good at soccer was the only way I could earn my love for it, that if I didn't play well, if I didn't start, assist, score, or win, then I wasn't worthy of loving the game. But I was wrong. I let my passion get tied up in stats, praise, and validation. When those things started to disappear, so did my self-worth.

But joy isn't something you earn with accolades and external confirmation. It's something you're allowed to feel, always. We live in a world obsessed with outcomes, stats, results, and highlights. It's easy to fall into the trap of thinking those things define you. But when the pressure to perform overtakes the joy of the game, you start to lose the very thing that made you fall in love in the first place.

So here's my advice to you – whether you're a soccer player, an artist, a student, or anybody with a dream to chase: never tie your self-worth to your success. Protect your joy. Water it. Guard it from the voices, external and internal, that try to convince you it's not enough.

Because at the end of the day, when the final whistle blows, when the game ends, when the lights go out, and the trophies gather dust, it's not the records you'll miss, it's the moments. The laughter, the thrill, the simple, sacred joy of doing something you love.

Tamara Andrew

Finding Purpose with Mobility Aids in a Bipedal World

My childhood was similar to many children who lived in my area. I fished, hill walked (hiked), trail blazed, climbed trees, rode horses, canoed, played soccer, and helped my parents with the garden. But at school, I learned I was different from others my age. I became good at resetting my joints, fingers, ankles, and toes. My first major dislocation was a shoulder in the third grade during gym. I developed a limp by fifth grade. My spine and hips began to curve and twist.

By eighth grade the school declared me a liability, and I was excused from the gym throughout high school. I was no longer allowed to play soccer on the school team. But I was in fierce denial and continued being as active as possible.

I used a cane on and off starting in college. It helped me when my balance was off. I used crutches when I couldn't trust one of my legs - but that made opening doors and using stairs very challenging. And, another issue, where to place them?

Crutches were a hindrance everywhere; whereas a cane was smaller and



easier to put to the side. On the other hand, when at a store where do you put the cane at the register? There is no place to rest it while you lean against the counter, but you can balance your weight on crutches.

After a couple of years of hinting, the day came that my doctor and I discussed a wheelchair, and I listened. I wanted to keep being active, but the act of walking a hallway was a challenge, even with a cane. Standing and sitting was a challenge. Stairs? A reason to find another way to my destination.

Six months later, my first designed-for-me wheelchair was ready! First thing I learned to do? Pop a wheelie. Then the reality of getting it in and out of my vehicle. Hills. Doors. Public restrooms. I didn't realize how many things I found a bit inconvenient with a cane suddenly became huge obstacles. But these became the obstacles to beat.

I spent time at the gym to strengthen my upper body. I figured out how to leverage myself to swing open a door. I enjoyed my new freedom too much to let stairs get in my way, but finding elevators was not always easy. I encountered narrow doorways that scraped my knuckles, tall thresholds the wheelie popping became important to cross, steps into spaces that I could now not enter. I learned about the ADA and the difference between compliance and accessibility and that being compliant with the ADA does not mean the space is accessible. I found that I needed to find the courage to use my voice since the few others I knew who daily used mobility aids said it wasn't worth their energy to speak up.

Where I find the biggest challenges are in public spaces. Parking that has narrow loading zones or people parked in the zone and your only option to leave your vehicle is to step onto a curb. Restaurants that have the ramp access in the back, by the dumpster, and through the kitchen. Stores that have racks and shelves so close I cannot get through without switching to my cane, and sometimes clothing racks are still too close for using the cane. Checking out at a store and there is no place to lean my cane, or me, while getting my payment ready, but in a wheelchair you cannot always reach the counter due to its height or all the merch hanging or stacked in front of it. Crumbling ramps and damaged pavement on sidewalks trapping wheels or tipping the chair. Doors that do not have electronic openers and are heavy, difficult to swing open. Doors that have electronic openers but something is in front of it, like a trash can. Countertops that are so high that the person behind cannot see me are everywhere; from medical

centers to car service departments to college comptroller offices. “Accessible” bathrooms where stalls that are too narrow for a wheelchair or counters too high to reach the sink.

Not only public places, but also homes are also not designed for limited mobility. Many have stairs to enter or to access upper floors, small bathrooms, narrow hallways and doorways. Kitchens are set up for people with no disabilities with tall appliances, upper cabinets, and sink cabinets that hinder access.

All of these challenges are because those who design or approve the modifications to spaces do not understand the challenges. Accessible spaces are useful to everyone, whether temporarily or permanently using mobility aids, carrying a heavy load, pushing a cart, holding hands with children, but non-accessible spaces are useful only to those without mobility aids. It gives the impression those of us who use aids are not wanted in those spaces.

I use my voice to bring awareness, but it can be exhausting to always advocate, especially when it may seem I am only advocating for myself. But this is so much bigger than one person’s needs.

As a child and teen, even into my early twenties, I tried to hide my challenges by becoming an overachiever in respect to my growing list of disabilities. I pushed myself to do more physically than my body could handle; I’d wrap my joints in tape or bind them in cloth and sticks before physio tape became available, I’d push myself to run, jump rope, climb trees, and ignore pain. A doctor’s opinion was a challenge to beat. I did not want to be seen as different.

But, as my disabilities became more apparent and painful, my view of myself and my world changed. I still had the urge to push myself, but I realized that I was not alone. These were generational family disabilities, but also others had them. Diagnoses helped me understand that there were others like me and I could learn from them.

Knowing many did not have the drive to be part of the bipedal world that blocks us from accessing so many wonders around us was my new challenge; to show the world that the physically challenged could be active, contributing members of society. Now, I even follow feeds and podcasts from others who are vocal about accessing the world. However, I find my place is to bring awareness to accessible spaces within my small sphere.

John Coffin ’25

Finding Purpose in the Void: Reframing My Mindset After Multiple Concussions

I lay staring at the off-white ceiling of my bedroom in Rennes, France, wrestling with the fact that I had received a third concussion and with painful knowledge that this burden would soon fall on my host family’s shoulders. Head spinning, temples pulsating, I found myself devoid of purpose. It felt like everytime I tried to live my life, to live as the person I had once been, the reality that I so desperately sought, slunk ever so slightly further out of my reach. Honestly, I was terrified. The great divide I sought to span between the reality that had once been mine and the current condition I was in now felt inconceivably wide, and no matter how hard I tried to ignore this, it left a sinking feeling in my stomach that couldn’t be shaken. I couldn’t accept that the life I once lived was over.

When I first arrived at Hotchkiss, I defined my purpose through progress. This meant maxing out a lift every time I entered the gym, writing all my essays in one sitting and, in the summers, never running less mileage than the week prior. The leaps and bounds that I made through this way of life left me content. I had a drive to get better, however the motivation was largely external. I think I wanted to be seen. This type of progress through which I found a drive to be stronger and faster was motivated by how intensely concerned I was with how others would perceive me. I wrote essays last minute because I was afraid of them not being good enough and afraid of the grade that would display this fact. I was self-conscious and this was reflected in how I found purpose in life.

Then, over the spring break of my sophomore year, I received a life altering concussion. A fog enveloped my brain and the menial tasks of everyday life became disturbingly difficult. I was no longer able to take care of basic responsibilities such as completing homework or arriving on time to classes or appointments. This led to, despite the efforts of doctors whom I saw on a regular basis, my withdrawal from Hotchkiss due to my inability to complete a sufficient amount of coursework. However, despite my misfortune, I had a chance to start over. The next year, I was going to live

with a host family and repeat my sophomore year at SYA France.
I arrived in France feeling hopeful for the chance to escape the invisible symptoms that had eluded doctors for the past six months. I wanted to try everything the town had to offer; I wanted to be everything I always had been. So I joined the track team, got a gym membership, and started going out on weekends. However, soon, I was faced with the bitter truth: my life was different now. A month in, I found myself lying in bed on the second floor of my host family's house having received a third concussion, injured from running and lifting too much too quickly, and suffering from my first bout of COVID. It felt like God was shooting down every effort I gave; like I wasn't adequate to live a normal life on this earth.

Yet, through these efforts to gain entry into this foreign society, I found myself surrounded by a welcoming and encouraging crowd who laid the foundation through which I began to reframe how I approached the world and how I found purpose in life. In France, while I still attacked every workout or goal with the same gusto as before, through the guidance of my running coach, I did learn to separate the results from my self worth. Through my conversations with him about his recently deceased wife and the two daughters he was now raising alone at home, both my age, I soon came to understand the motivations behind his commitment to each and every runner in his club. He showed me that, despite the setbacks in my health and in my grades, I still had a lot. I learned the value of relationships. Instead of showing up to the workout or race to set a new personal record, I did it to connect with the runners around me. And they took me on long runs, drove me to races, and showed me a new home.
Two years later, during the summer before my senior year, I truly left my past behind and morphed into something new, something heavily influenced by the framework I developed in France. Through adversity, I was freed from my haunting past and overwhelming future. I built the patience necessary to live in the present trying to make the best of each moment with those around me. And without the constant, self obsessed drone of regrets and lost dreams from the past and future lying clouding my vision, the self-consciousness that forced my purpose to be defined through progress withered away creating a space to build true motivation.

The world I was discovering is best de scribed through the void. The void is a space devoid of time, and without time, anxiety, too, ceases. At first there is great pain, but through focus, a rhythm, like an endless sea of rolling waves, begins to form. This undulating flow sucks me out of the chamber of time through which the unfounded anxieties of the rational mind echo. Without pain and the anxiety of an end, a finish, I am no longer trying to reach, I am free. My motivation in this state

is, at its root, created out of action itself. I take this step because I am running, and I take this stroke on the erg because I am rowing.

This state was made possible through my detachment from the results of my efforts, a detachment from an end. Ironically, during efforts in which I entered this state, the results were always much greater. By finding purpose in the action itself instead of the means, rooting myself deeply into my current reality, I found myself able to spread my wings. After encountering this void, this flow state while running during that summer, now nearly a year ago, I decided to try to bring it to my life. Instead of studying to get better grades, I began entering each assignment with the goal to learn as much as possible from it. Instead of losing sleep over the symptoms of my concussions, specifically over the fear that the symptoms would continue forever, I instead accepted each moment as my reality and attempted to live each moment, like each step of a cross country race, as best I could. Through the complete and utter simplification of every aspect of my life, I was liberated from the cuffs that time places on the mind.

Trying to live in this way, however, is difficult, especially while living in a society where our ever growing knowledge is framed by the static unchanging transcripts that don't even begin to capture the growth in knowledge that Hotchkiss students constantly acquire. And in the same static nature that our forever growing knowledge is captured, students also frame their perception of the ever growing and changing students around them. At the end of the day, I receive a transcript that is supposed to represent all the knowledge that grew inside me in my five years at Hotchkiss, and the students around me [may?] only remember the discombobulated me that returned to Hotchkiss unhealed and afraid of the world two years ago. Due to the nature of the system in which we are evaluated at Hotchkiss, the mind of the Hotchkiss student is threatened with becoming blinded by arbitrary results and the deeply rooted perceptions of others which are not representative of the true growth of character and knowledge that students go through at Hotchkiss. This journey is about my efforts to escape the manufactured systems of thought that once defined my purpose, and while I now know the void through which I seek to build my purpose out of, I can't give a specific definition to my purpose. It is, by definition, an endless journey; an endless sea of rolling waves.

Alessandro Araujo ’26

How One Series of Mistakes Shifted My Ideals

I’m not a very religious person. Far from it. However, I can certainly get behind many religious values, as I’ve analyzed religions with a more philosophical lens than as a plausible view on how creation occurred and existence must be guided (listen to “Vulture” by Bear Ghost if you want to see my perspective on the corruption of religion). As a result, many of my values and mantras are somewhat derived from religion: treating others as one would like to be treated (the Golden Rule), being gracious to or with others, and, most importantly, the “what goes around comes around” ideal of karma. When I repeat these mantras to others (and as I write this actually), I feel a bit corny, but they are integral to how I lead my life both at Hotchkiss and beyond.

Karma and the Golden Rule have helped me live at peace with myself. As I write this, the period in which I grew the most as a person would likely be during 7th and 8th grade. Unfortunately, I had crossed some boundaries due to poor communication between my peers, and, after a swath of rumor-spreading, these missteps were blown out of proportion into countless wrongful claims. These rumors severely impacted my reputation and relationships with people and continues to follow me even here at Hotchkiss, where some seem uncomfortable simply in my presence. This social isolation and constant demonization from my own peers had made me depressed and, at some points, induced suicidal ideations, as my life and identity began to revolve so much around these rumors where I felt like there was no escape other than ridding the community of the root of the problem: myself.

I knew once I started getting these terrible feelings and thoughts that I had to change and do something for myself and my community. I felt like I owed my middle-school community an address (much like this one for you all) to combat the negative karma I had accumulated from my mistakes (despite the sheer difference in gravity between the rumors and reality). So when I had to deliver my valedictory at my middle school graduation, I took my last opportunity to ad-



dress my cohort as a whole. I addressed the rumors. I addressed that I had made members of my community uncomfortable, and I apologized and used it as the theme for my speech: how mistakes can be weaponized both negatively and positively and that they should be used more for the latter. I added that people that make mistakes should also be given some grace, as some mistakes are made in good faith. Ever since I proclaimed that way of living to my colleagues and friends, I've trodden? that path.

On that path, many of my actions have felt restorative for both my reputation and pride. I have learned to communicate better so that those mistakes will never happen again, and so that I can lead by example. I am cautious to not make people feel uncomfortable, no matter how forward or extroverted I can be. I made a conscious effort to handle all multi-faceted situations from a nuanced frame, as I myself have experienced what can happen when one person does not do so and acts upon the situation only considering one possibility for the circumstances of an act. All of these actions and improvements have helped me feel like the discomfort of my peers was not in vain and that I have repaid my debt to the people who I had wronged. Under the lens of karma, the overt punishment from my peers felt like a hard kick that taught me to be wary of the impact of my actions (sometimes a little too much, to be honest), but the overt nature of the punishment also reminded me of the Golden Rule and that I should treat others with grace in case the judgment cast upon them was undue. I try to be kind to all and help people as much as I can, as I know that, in my late times in middle school, while I had masked my pain, all of the little aggressions and little moments of kindness served as a large release. So, I would hope that with my positive treatment of others, at some point that might come around to me!

Ultimately, here are three mantras that, in case you're looking for a TL;DR, I believe everyone should live by:
One who makes a misstep must reclaim it and repurpose it for the greater good.
One who seeks grace must be gracious.
One who seeks solace must provide it.
And one more as an extra for reading the end! Live life like a cartoon: you'll never get tired of it.

Olivia Hicks ’27

Is There Truly One Way to Be Happy?

I often wonder what true happiness is. Is it better to experience intense joy for a briefperiod, followed by stress and anxiety for a longer stretch, or should we endure some discomfort now for the promise of happiness later? These questions plague me while studying for tests or writing a research paper. Is my current happiness worth not studying and being upset by my poor grades later?



Even the word “happiness” raises debate about whether it is referring to the fleeting emotion or the overall wellbeing of the person. This debate appears in many philosophies of contrasting ideas. However, I believe true happiness is closely tied to overall wellbeing. After experiencing both scenarios, I believe that a happy life comes from walking the fine line between finding joy in the moment while also setting yourself up for success in the future. However, my perspective is challenged by many other philosophies.

Hedonism is a philosophy that believes having a happy life comes from having as many pleasant experiences as possible while minimizing the unpleasant ones. This means that you should always make choices that bring you the most happiness or pleasure in the moment, not looking into the future. Although this idea is understandable, with-

out thinking about the future or the consequences of your actions, you are possibly setting yourself up for an unhappier future. To live a happy life, you need to be cautious about the consequences of your actions, even if they bring you happiness in the moment.

A theory that focuses more on balance is the Life Satisfaction Theory, focusing on the entire well-being of your life versus certain decisions. The total measure of one's happiness is determined by four components such as engagement, relationships, meaning, and accomplishments. This idea has also been adopted by psychologists, who created ways to improve your life satisfaction by promoting activities such as trying new things, spending time with others, and always putting 100% effort into everything you do. This philosophy is one that I agree with since it evaluates your life as a whole to increase your overall satisfaction, not just happiness in one moment.

Emotional State View also looks at your overall life, but specifically your emotions. It says that the decisions you should be making are the ones that bring you the most happiness now and in the future. This is also applicable to decisions that help your general emotional wellbeing rather than just one's happiness. The Emotional State View even goes so far to say that happiness is more than just feeling good, almost the opposite of hedonism.

For me, the philosophy that is most applicable to my life is the Life Satisfaction Theory because it addresses every aspect of life as well as giving strategies to improve your happiness. While the Emotional State View is a close second, prioritizing my overall well being might lead me to make decisions I'll regret in the future like spending time with friends instead of studying. That said, I believe there is a middle ground between these two philosophies, one that you put just enough studying or time feeling unpleasant to get the outcome you want, while creating time to do the things you love. Pushing through the tough moments to benefit you in the future is an important part of leading a good life so that you can maximize your happiness in the future.

Keith Moon

Skating to Victory

"Mister, Mister…you from USA? Mister, Mister…speak English?"

There I stood, head to toe in Slovakian gear—a Slovakian flag on the front of my jacket, the name Slovakia across my hat and the back of my jacket, and a Slovakian flag on my backpack, but somehow this Italian kid, who looked to be a middle schooler, had me all figured out. Maybe he'd heard me say something to my friend, though I really didn't think I had said anything for several minutes.

"Yeah, do you?" I responded. He shook his head quickly and then just let out a big smile. "USA?" he asked again. "Yep, I'm American." He beamed at me and then turned around to tell his friends all about me; they each snuck a peek at me too.

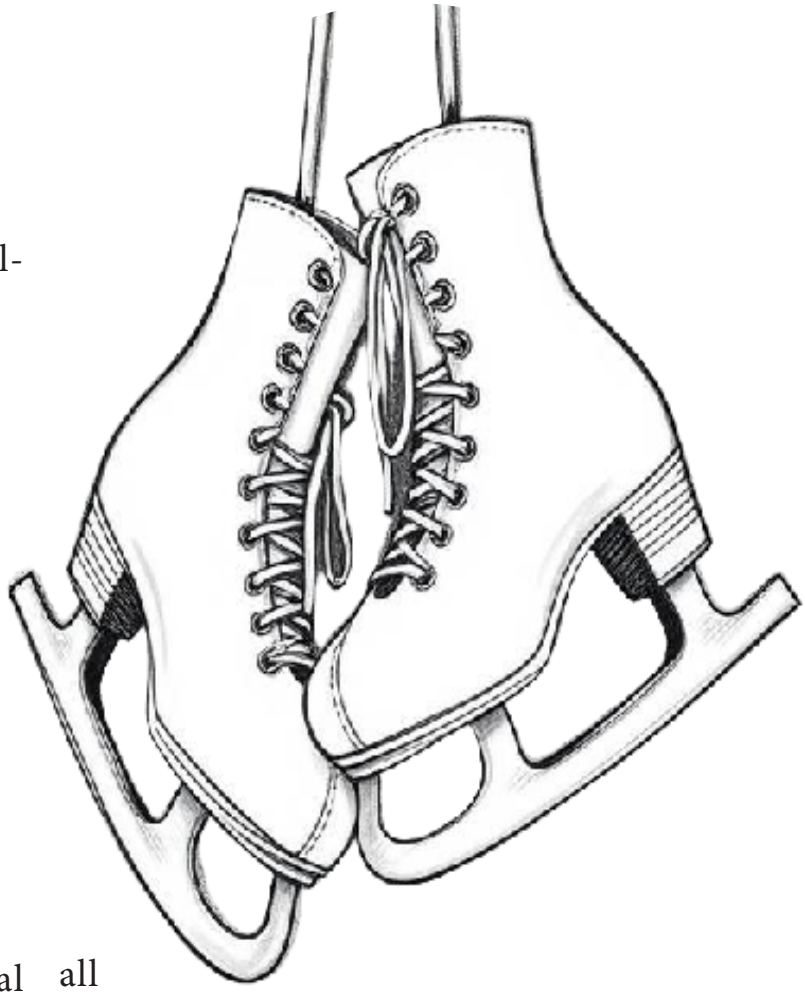
Twenty minutes earlier, he and 200 noisy but eager and polite 12 year olds had piled into the hockey rink stands to cheer for the Special Olympians competing in speed skating at the Special Olympics Winter World Games in Torino, Italy, last month. It was a day off from school for these "Class Five" students, as their teacher explained to me later, but they looked a little older than 5th graders from the U.S. Still, they persisted in hanging onto the last cusp of childhood, these energetic kids: there were no cell phones or requests for food—these kids were here for an express purpose: cheering and having fun. They were remarkably well-behaved and positive, even when nothing much was happening on the ice in front of them.

After dedicating myself over the last few years to Special Olympics Slovakia and the Dream Day Center for Ukrainian refugee children born with intellectual disabilities, which opened after Russia started its bloody and cruel war with Ukraine in 2022, I had been invited to the World Games as an honorary delegate of Slovakia. The special guest pass around my neck allowed me to go anywhere at these Games; by the end of the week, I would see figure skating, alpine skiing, snow-shoeing, and cross-country skiing, along with the speedskating of this particular day, and I would march in

the closing ceremonies of the Games. Slovakia was cleaning up in almost every event: the little nation of 5.5 million would earn 34 medals by week's end, a massive haul in a competition that included scores of countries. Only Canada and Norway seemed to be able to compete with the Slovakians when gold medals were on the line.

Back at the skating rink, the first time I heard a nation mentioned, it was easy to pick out. "USA, USA, USA" the whole crowd of Italian children chanted in unison. When I looked up, there was the athlete from the United States leading the divisional heat that would ultimately lead to her gold medal in the 1000-meter speed skating final. I didn't resist: I chanted along too, because why not? There were no Slovakians in the race and our American skater was doing spectacularly well. The chant was rhythmic and passionate, but somehow bore none of the over-confident bluster that an actual American crowd might sneak into a USA chant.

Soon, when a new heat started, the Italian kids had switched over to cheering for Ungheria, which it took me a few seconds to realize was Hungary. They yelled with the same gusto and assurance that they had chanted USA. As the morning progressed, we



all chanted for Messico (Mexico), Polonia (Poland), and Norvegia (Norway) with utter abandon.

Just before noon, a remarkable heat of just two athletes was brought to the starting line. Two women, one from Poland and one from Iran, had handlers with them to help them get lined up; this race was from the 1.1.1 division, the low numbers indicating that these were some of the most disabled athletes in these Games. Their task was to make it one lap around the Olympic-sized hockey rink, which some skaters had done in just seconds earlier in the day. But this pair would not

move so quickly—the Polish woman, by far the better skater, took almost two and a half minutes to complete the circuit once.

But pretty quickly, all eyes were on the Iranian skater, a young woman named Bita who was doing everything she knew how to do just to put one foot cautiously in front of the other and not fall. When the race started, she looked perplexed and scared, as the woman who had skated with her to the starting line had to slip away and let her compete on her own.

Bita immediately turned to see if anyone would come to her rescue, but then she remembered that she had come to compete and she turned forward and took tiny strides to move down the ice. Her coach, a man whose clothes all were emblazoned with the name Iran and the Iranian flag, shouted and pleaded with her in Farsi from behind the boards to skate, to use her legs, to keep moving.

She followed his guidance, but then would look back to see him and that would bring her precipitously close to falling. He started to run around the outside of the rink, on the other side of the boards from the ice, so he could get to the next opening in the glass to shout for her to keep skating. He never took his eyes off her.

Slowly but surely, Bita was making her way. The first skater had finished her single lap before Bita had made even one major turn on the ice: for a brief moment, they were both heading in the same direction, though Bita's journey was just beginning and the Polish skater's lap was finished. The Italian kids, still chanting Polonia lustfully, were just starting to shift their understanding of what was happening on the ice. This race was not about who was leading or who would get the gold medal, the whole crowd seemed to realize at the same time: this race was about Bita.

She never gained much confidence, but Bita just kept going, inching her way across the ice, arms flailing a bit each time she thought she was going to fall. For a split second, the Italian kids started up with L'Iran, but that didn't last: a much more resounding and passionate chant began that didn't let up until she had made her way all the way around the rink: Bee-ta, Bee-ta, Bee-ta. Everyone was on their feet, cheering it, all of us transfixed on this slow-moving figure on the ice and the running, screaming coach who ducked his head in wherever he could to plead with Bita to keep skating.

It took over six minutes for Bita to complete her lap, but she did it. Pan-

demonium ruled the rink: the Italian kids were in a paroxysm of delight and rapture when she made it back across the starting line. Everyone continued chanting Bee-ta!, Bee-ta!, Bee-ta! while her coach rushed out to collect her and bring her over to the post-race station, where she stood for several minutes just smiling at the rest of the Iranian team and the crowd. Everyone in the building was excited beyond measure and the coach was still racing all over, unable yet to control his emotions. I decided I needed to share with Bita's family just how much her skating had meant to all of us.

So, there I was, standing face-to-face with Bita's mother, who was weeping gently, and I realized that because of a significant language gap neither of us could speak to the other. I wanted her to know how proud I was of her daughter, but also how remarkable it was that the whole stadium had come together for this one brave skater. But I don't speak Farsi and Bita's mother didn't know what to do with my Slovakian outfit—she certainly didn't speak Slovak.

Realizing that my outfit was confusing to her, I said, "Oh! I am an American!"—patting myself on the chest as if that would make it somehow clearer that I was from the United States. "I speak English," I shouted.

That didn't really help. Bita's mother blushed and said, "no English, no English," so I just repeatedly said Bita and put my thumbs up in the air. We both said Bita a few more times and smiled broadly—she was thrilled that the place had noticed her daughter.

Finally, I turned to go, but the mother grabbed at me and held my arm for a moment, while she spoke quickly to the woman next to her. When I turned back, she said softly, in very hesitating and accented English, "I respect your American flag." This was very important for her to say to me—I could see it in her eyes. It was clear to me that she wanted the same thing I did: a human moment of caring, irrespective of whatever nonsensical tensions there might be between governments.

I witnessed some extraordinary moments of athleticism all week at the World Games, and the sheer ability of some of the athletes was just a marvel. Bita was not a great athlete and she wasn't going to go home with many medals, but she won the heart of everyone in that rink that day.

She was brave in the attempt, the very essence of the Special Olympics motto, and we were all with her for those six intense, challenging, and remarkable minutes. Suddenly, none of the nationalities mattered—the Italians, Slovaks,

Americans, Canadians, Norwegians, and Iranians were all Bita fans, and really nothing more.

If 36 years at Hotchkiss have taught me anything, it's simply that you never know who is going to move you and push you forward. We come to this school from all over the country and the world in just the way the Special Olympics athletes went to Italy, with great hope and sense of purpose both in meeting new people while also representing home and family with everything we've got.



It's a great question to ask ourselves as we go: what am I doing here and how can I make this go the very best that it can? That doesn't have to mean straight A's or being a varsity captain or winning a New England championship. Sometimes it just means staying upright all the way around the rink, metaphorically as well as literally.

At the very end of the rink session, my original Italian middle school buddy popped up just as I was putting my hat and gloves on. "Arrivederci," I said. "Bye Bye, Mister America," he said, and then quickly turned back to cheer on the next gold medalist. He had much more important things to attend to than to bother with me anymore.

Paul Sperry

Scouting - A Path to Eudaimonia

Back in my teens, I was a Boy Scout. Like most kids, I joined for the hiking, canoeing, and camping. But Scouting offers much more than outdoor adventure. It fosters leadership, encourages healthy living, and introduces young people to a vast range of interests through merit badges.

From Mammal Study to Moviemaking, Painting to Pets, Radio to Railroading, and Scuba Diving to Sculpture–Scouting opens doors to about 140 different human endeavors.With a bit of stick-to-itiveness, role modeling from peers, and plenty of adult guidance, I earned my Eagle Scout when I was 17–nearly 60 years after my grandfather had earned his!

At the time, I'd never heard the term "eudaimonia". But when asked to write for this publication, I was delighted to learn of it because it captures the essence of what I hope for myself, my family, and my students: to live a flourishing life, rooted in virtue, reason, health, and a pursuit of excellence in all areas. When one flourishes, one is happy, and that happiness inevitably spreads to others.



I am fortunate that my grandfather was able to attend my Eagle Scout Court of Honor, a ceremony celebrating one's path to becoming an Eagle Scout. I had invited him to say a few words about his own experience and the role Scouting played in his long life. He shared humorous stories about teenage boys having fun

in the outdoors, and getting into trouble in the 1920s, reminding us some things in our rapidly changing world never change! But then he shifted to what helped him truly flourish–across nine decades of school, work, marriage, family, and, one we don't always think about as an important and particularly challenging part of life, aging.

For him, the foundation of eudaimonia was always grounded in the Scout Law and Oath–two guiding principles all scouts must learn to earn their first rank of Tenderfoot. Whenever the path was unclear, or things were confusing, these tenets offered clarity and direction. They kept him focused on virtue, reason, health, and pursuit of excellence in all aspects of his life.

And so, like him to me, I offer you the Scout Law and Scout Oath, as a compass–one that might help you find your own path toward eudaimonia. As you read them, I suspect you may find, as I have, their similarity to the foundational ethics and values of the major spiritual paths of humanity, suggesting their truth through the ages of all cultures.

If you ever find yourself unsure which path to take when faced with a decision, big or small, I urge you to let these Scouting tenets guide you to your own eudaimonia, or flourishing life!

THE SCOUT OATH
On my honor I will do my best to do my duty to God and my country and to obey the Scout Law; to help other people at all times; to keep myself physically strong, mentally awake, and morally straight.
THE SCOUT LAW
The Scout Law has 12 points. Each is a goal for every Scout. A Scout tries to live up to the Law every day. It is not always easy to do, but a Scout always tries.
A Scout is:

TRUSTWORTHY. Tell the truth and keep promises. People can depend on you.

LOYAL. Show that you care about your family, friends, Scout leaders, school, and country.

HELPFUL. Volunteer to help others without expecting a reward.

FRIENDLY. Be a friend to everyone, even people who are very different from you.

COURTEOUS. Be polite to everyone and always use good manners.

KIND. Treat others as you want to be treated. Never harm or kill any living

thing without good reason.

OBEDIENT*. Follow the rules of your family, school, and team. Obey the laws of your community and country.

CHEERFUL. Look for the bright side of life. Cheerfully do tasks that come your way. Try to help others be happy.

THRIFTY. Work to pay your own way. Try not to be wasteful. Use time, food, supplies, and natural resources wisely.

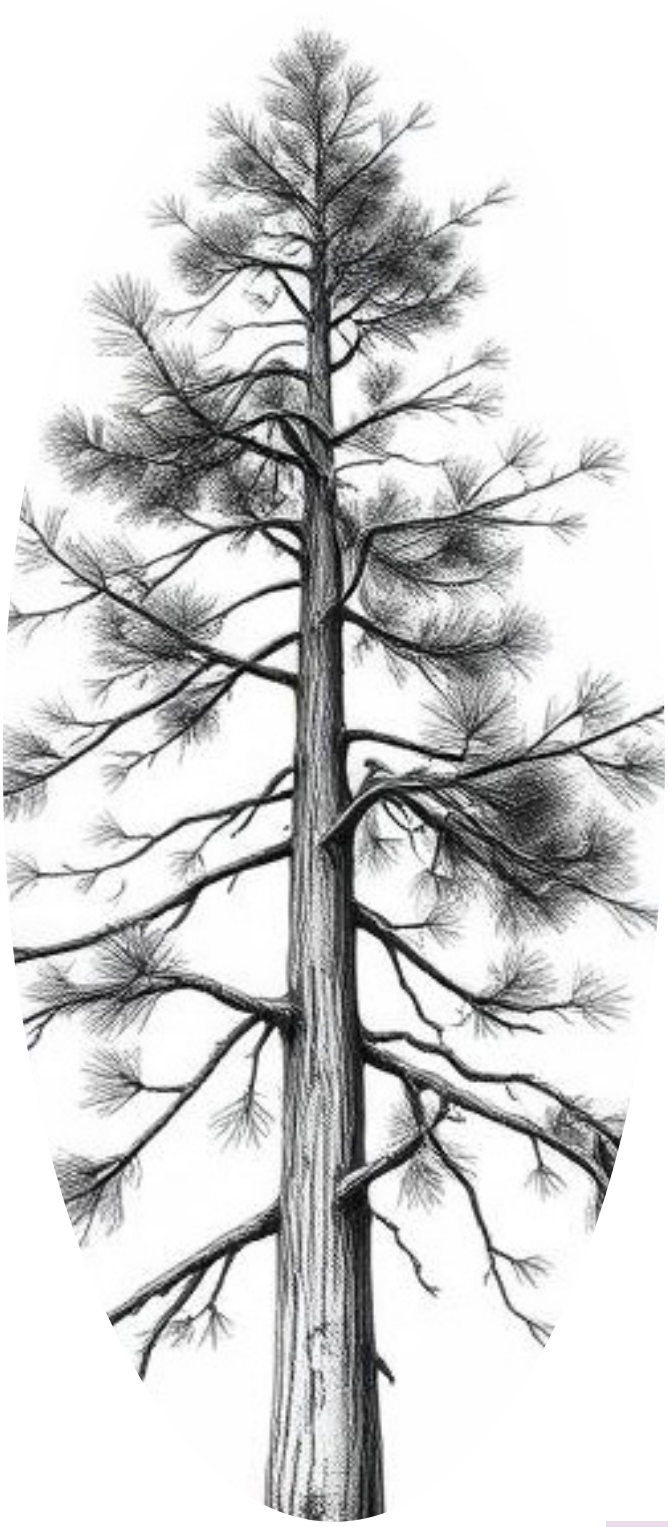
BRAVE. Face difficult situations even when you feel afraid. Do what you think is right despite what others might be doing or saying.

CLEAN. Keep your body and mind fit. Help keep your home and community clean.

REVERENT. Be reverent toward God**. Be faithful in your religious duties. Respect the beliefs of others.

* I take the meaning of obedient here to be akin to respectful, but not unquestioning. If you don't understand the intent of a rule, you should ask about it. If the rule still seems unjust, then you should work civilly to change it to make it just.

** In my reading of reverent, I substitute the term "God" with the Native American concept of "Great Spirit", suggesting humility in the knowledge of greater forces running through all things in our lives, living and nonliving.



Charlotte Schills ’26

A Dutch Heart in an American World: Finding My Place as an International Student at Hotchkiss

Before I left for the United States last summer, I said goodbye to my friends and family — not forever, just a “see you later”, knowing I would be back in five months. But I realise now I never said goodbye to who I was: a 16 year old, leaving my home in The Hague, the Netherlands, to study at Hotchkiss as a new upper-mid. Though I had lived in five countries, I had always moved with my parents and brother who provided support when facing the difficulties that come with living abroad. But this was my first “solo adventure”. I was going to experience a whole new culture, but unlike the five other times, on my own. With a six-hour time difference, it can be challenging to call my parents because they have busy schedules, too; I went from seeing them every day, to only speaking to them through FaceTime once a week, maybe twice if I was lucky. Being an international student at Hotchkiss is not easy, but it is also a unique experience that has already changed me, more than I imagined it would.

The challenges of being international started at the airport. Saying goodbye to my family, my friends, and my country last summer was not just hard, it was painful. I willingly stepped on a plane away from all of them, knowing I wouldn’t see most of them until my return in December. And each time I board a plane away from home, I still feel that now familiar pang — but with every new connection I make at Hotchkiss, the excitement grows, too. Only when planes get cancelled, delays make me miss connections, my bags get damaged, I hate the planes that have taken me from adventure to adventure ever since I was a small kid. In those moments, I feel the weight of being alone, with no friend, or family member to help me or give me a hug, because I am the only Dutch student at Hotchkiss. There are other moments when I realise this, too, but this one is the most painful because I am either finally going home, or have to leave home behind. Both those occasions are exciting, but going home is even more so because it doesn’t happen of-

ten. Sometimes it takes 2, 3, or even 5 months before I finally get to go home again. So when there are delays or people around me who went home just last week or whose parents could come visit just for a day say "I miss home", it does hurt a little, even though everyone is entitled to missing home.
And aside from the people and places, I also miss the food and speaking Dutch with others. I miss eating my mum's food and Dutch delicacies like boerenkool and bitterballen. I miss being able to switch from French to English to Dutch and people being able to follow my conversation. And I miss hearing the harsh syllables of the Dutch language because it reminds me of home. On most days, I'll not even stop to think about these things, but on others all these things combined really make me miss home, sometimes even to the point where I question whether coming here was the right decision. But luckily, I have great friends here at Hotchkiss, some of whom are also international and understand these feelings, and help me remember why I came here and that these feelings are only temporary.
One thing that doesn't get easier with time though, is not being able to celebrate important dates and traditions in Dutch culture, like Sinterklaas. It's the Dutch version of Christmas and, unless you are Christian, is often the most important day in December. Every year, it's on the 6th of December and for the first time in 17 years, I didn't celebrate it. I wasn't with my family and I didn't exchange gifts and poems to celebrate a day of giving. I FaceTimed my mum, who was at my aunt's with the whole family. When the time came for them to go to bed, I went to the dining hall; I have never felt more alone and homesick than I did at that moment. There, I thought about all the differences in American culture when compared to the Dutch one. From something as simple as hugs to dining habits and what is considered polite, the differences seemed unbridgeable. For example, most people in the Netherlands, even a stranger to you, would approach you and ask to give you a hug if they saw you were upset about something. But I knew that physical contact, even between friends and family, was much less abundant than back home, so I smiled until a friend of mine from Ukraine asked me if I was okay. As I looked up and told her about my evening and how painful it was not to be celebrating Sinterklaas at all, she gave me a hug, and I was so thankful to her.

Moments like those make me realise that I am international, and have different customs, ideologies, and a different background. But it's moments like people asking you about what the Netherlands is like, saying they have been there, when I learn something new about the U.S.. or American cul-



ture, or when I'm asked to share my perspective on a matter, that remind me why I came to Hotchkiss. I came to Hotchkiss to experience a new culture, one I had very little knowledge of, except for things I knew from my American friends or the movies. Here, I get the opportunity to explore American culture whilst simultaneously bringing a different perspective to the classroom, problem solving, and even extracurricular activities. The most interesting and enjoyable conversations are the ones where I get to learn the 'American way' and I get to share my Dutch/European way or thoughts on a matter without immediately being judged for the differences between our 'ways'. It's really easy to spot the differences between cultures, people or even ideologies, but it's the similarities that unite us. I often have to remind myself to look for the familiarities or similarities between Hotchkiss and my home on days I'm a little homesick, but it's also a practice that has allowed me to connect with so many different people on a daily basis. Finding the differences may seem easier, but identifying similarities is what connects and unites us, and is crucial to living in diverse communities.

And out of the many more fantastic aspects about being an international student at Hotchkiss, coming home and having everyone begging to hear all your stories might be my favourite one. They ask about so many things ranging from what new things I learned in the classroom and from my peers, to funny stories and moments from my time here. I'm always honest, meaning if they ask about hardships I don't coddle it (being direct and honest is a very Dutch thing to do) as being an international student is a double-edged sword: all the fun and excitement does come at a cost.

So when people ask me what it's like, I say: It's goodbyes and hellos. Tears and laughter. Pain and joy. Moments missed but memories created. You will feel misunderstood, lost and alone, but also unique, celebrated, and free to explore on your own. It shapes not just your life, but also shapes who you are and will become. It's an experience. A journey. And above all else, something unforgettable that has made me more resilient, reflective, and open to even

Sungyun Kim ’27

Fostering Eudaimonia With Empathy: What Tourette‘s Syndrome Taught Me

On the first day of my seventh grade year, a kid screamed in my ear. I was surprised and I shot him a sharp glare to let him know that I was annoyed. However, I soon learned about Tourette Syndrome and realized that the kid I had glared at was struggling with involuntary actions he couldn’t control. I remember him still being positive, even when he was in a situation that might seem hopeless to others. He and I became good friends later that year, and my experience with him motivated me to do a bit more research about Tourette syndrome.

I realized that Tourette syndrome is often misunderstood or largely unknown due to its portrayal in social media and news articles. Among children diagnosed with Tourette syndrome, a significant number also experience other disorders. Children with Tourette syndrome may face unique challenges, including an increased risk of bullying due to their noticeable symptoms. Such harassment can significantly impact a child’s mental health, leading to issues like depression, anxiety, and low self-esteem. It is crucial to recognize that bullying is not just a normal part of growing up but a serious issue that requires attention and intervention. Support from parents, teachers, and peers is vital in helping children with Tourette syndrome overcome bullying. People often get annoyed and disturbed by the abrupt actions of people diagnosed with Tourette syndrome without understanding their situation. People must inform themselves about mental issues so that they can understand and develop empathy for what individuals with neurological disorders are going through.

My personal journey learning about Tourette has taught me the lesson of thinking more profoundly than my initial judgments. It has influenced my personal philosophy by teaching me that patience, and empathy are essential not only in how we treat others but also in how we approach challenges in our own lives. It has shown me that it is not the severity of the conflicts that determines our lives, but rather our reaction to them. By embracing differences rather than fearing them, we can create a world where individuals with neurological disorders are treated with respect and compassion rather than bias and misunderstanding.

Sienna Hwang '27

Pursuit of Happiness on a Fairway

I was twelve years old when I accidentally discovered old YouTube clips of the 2004 Sony Open. Michelle Wie, only two years senior to me at the time, striped drives and sank putts against her much stronger adult male competitors on the way to playing a record-breaking round of 68. I asked my parents for a golf lesson the day after, and I haven't looked back since – sort of.



The crisp, earthy smell of fresh-cut grass when I step onto the first tee box. The explosive thwack of the ball when I hit it perfectly with my driver. The soft rattle around the cup when I drain a putt. The rewards I experienced were immediately gratifying and vividly intense, and I chased those highs relentlessly.

As a twelve-year-old, I had found my hedonistic pursuit of pleasure! While tragic to the rest of humanity, the pandemic was a God-given time for me. I would listen to my virtual classes and finish my homework in the car on the way to various municipal golf courses around New York City, just so that I could fully indulge in my daily 18-hole rounds without a worry in the world. Nowhere did I feel more alive and invigorated than on a golf course.

Then something happened. All the joyful time I spent pursuing my hedonistic pleasure actually made me good at golf. In the beginning, it all started rather innocently – my coach suggest-

ed it would be good for me to play in a local U.S. Kids tournament. Despite having "U.S." in its name, the tournament is a local event designed to promote "fun" in golf through stress-free, beginner competition.

When I showed promise throughout the first few tournaments, my coach encouraged my parents to sign me up for a more competitive regional tour that draws players from tri-state areas of New York, New Jersey, and Connecticut.

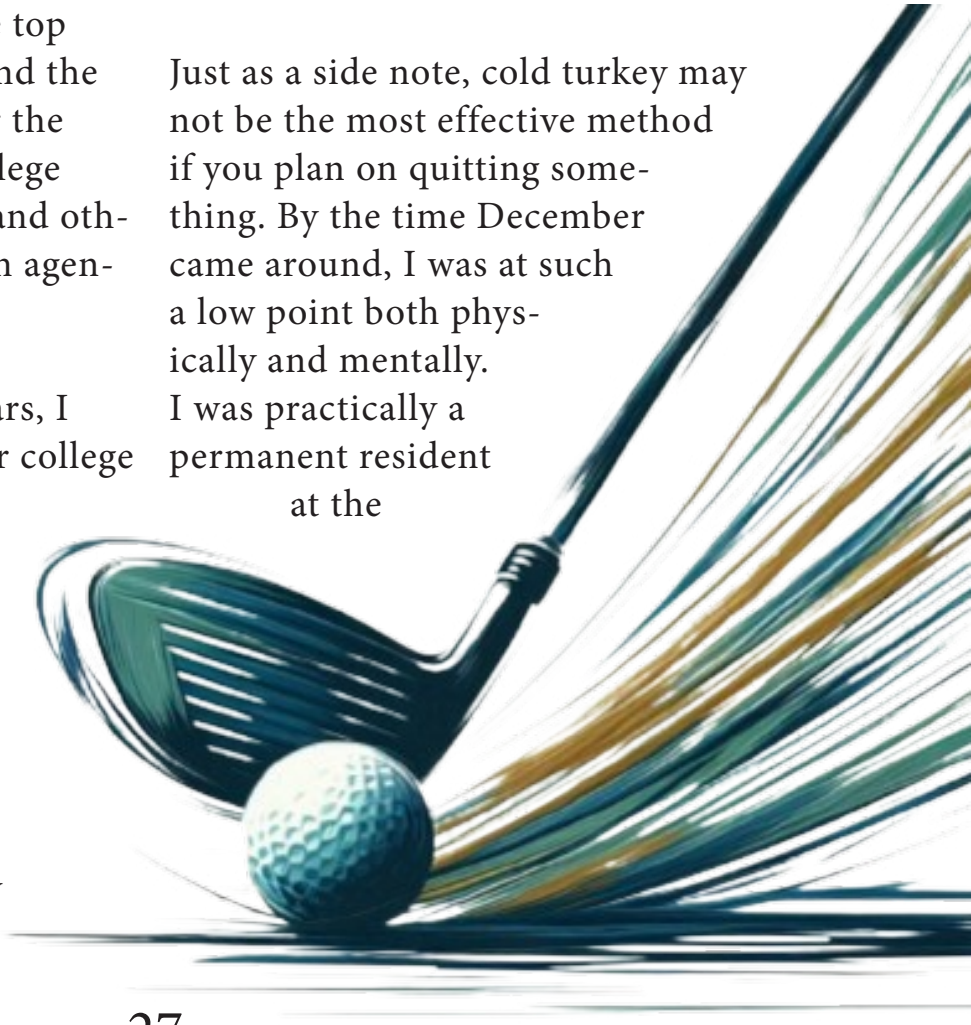
By the time four years passed by at a lightning speed, I found myself competing in American Junior Golf Association tournaments – where top players from the U.S. and around the world gather to compete under the nerve-wrecking scrutiny of college coaches, consultants, parents, and other spectators, all with their own agendas.

At some point during these years, I had decided that I would go for college recruiting. I'm not going to lie – I thrive on the adrenaline rush of competition. But it would also be disingenuous of me to deny the existence of the dark side of competing at this level.

The overwhelming sense of joy from my earlier years had been shadowed by lofty expectations, self-doubt, the perpetual grind, and anxiety. Playing badly in tournaments meant staying awake at night, reliving my every mistake. Practicing for hours before and after school each day meant virtually no time to hang out with my friends. Instead of feeling invigorated, I felt like I was missing out on life.

My answer to my new-found misery? I decided to go cold turkey. And what better time to do that than when you move out of your home to a brand-new world full of strangers? I put down my clubs for four months at the start of my prep year at Hotchkiss.

Just as a side note, cold turkey may not be the most effective method if you plan on quitting something. By the time December came around, I was at such a low point both physically and mentally. I was practically a permanent resident at the



Health Center – spending more time there than in the classroom thanks to my body essentially breaking down from a hiatus after years of playing sports almost every day. Mentally, I felt an unidentifiable void that could [not] be filled with any amount of time spent with friends, family, food, travel, reading, or anything else.

At some point, I actually started missing the pain of golf – the stress of competition, grueling workload, and even the lofty expectation that others placed on me.

Perhaps it wasn't exactly healthy, but I came to think that a mind partially occupied by those burdens was actually better than a big, empty void. It was in December that I made an executive decision and signed myself up for a national tournament in North Carolina taking place during the Christmas week.

The results were predictable. My clubs refused to obey my brain. Balls were finding places on the course that I never knew existed. But I found the strange willpower to overcome the rust of not playing for four months. It was the determination that I did not want to feel that empty void ever again.

Even though the final results weren't amazing, it was pretty satisfying all things considered. For the next few months following the tournament, as I slowly eased back into golf, that fear of void transformed into something interesting.

I actually came to embrace the college recruiting part of the game. As the reality of college applications drew closer and I, all of sudden, woke up to a concept of "dream schools," I began to realize that this sport that I had such pure joy (and dread) for can actually couple as a way to secure my happiness in the future as well.

By recognizing this new purpose, I started embracing the pain and difficulty that came with this wonderful sport as necessities – two sides of the same coin. The happiness and fulfillment I will be experiencing at the end of it all will be so much more meaningful because I will know exactly the pain and challenges I had to work through before deserving it all. Thus, my pursuit of hedonism has changed.

It is no longer about chasing the instantly gratifying pleasures and purity of golf single-mindedly, but rather about embracing the full range of the experience – including pain and challenges – as a means to achieving eventual deeper happiness. It's a work in progress, but I am finally happy (and sometimes miserable) again.

